

THE ART OF THE WET FLY

1-Day Intensive · Student Handout

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8 hrs

7:30 AM – 3:15 PM

~5 hrs

ON-WATER TIME

8

SESSIONS

4

METHODS INTRODUCED

Traditional Swing · Davy Wotton Induced Method · Dead Drift Wet · Contact / Evolutionary

"The big advantage with these techniques is they empower the angler to really grid off massive amounts of water much quicker than any other method. That is the art — systematic coverage, not random casting."

INSTRUCTOR NOTE *The four-method framework cannot be fully mastered in one day. Prioritize the traditional swing and step-and-swing grid — those are the highest-return skills for immediate water coverage. Dead drift and Wotton are introduced; contact is introduced. Depth comes from the 2-day program.*

Quick Reference

FOUR METHODS AT A GLANCE

METHOD	DESCRIPTION
Traditional swing	Quarter-downstream cast on floating line, upstream mend, low rod track, let fly hang — step-and-swing grid covers all water.
Dead drift wet	Upstream 45° cast, high rod tracks fly downstream at current speed with zero tension. Most demanding line control in fly fishing.
Wotton induced method	Upstream, across, and downstream presentations with a cast of flies. Leisenring Lift at target lie triggers instinctive take.
Contact / evolutionary	Tight-line swing with gentle fly animation. Straight-down feed for unreachable lies. Rod-tap pulses for movement.

METHOD BY WATER TYPE

WATER TYPE	APPROACH
Riffles (1–3 ft)	Traditional swing on floating line — textured surface conceals approach, fast enough for active swing
Tailouts / pool tails	Slow swing on floating or intermediate — flies rise through depth at hang — prime strike zone
Pool heads	Dead drift or Wotton upstream — high energy, flies sink quickly; let current do the work
Inside bends & seams	Contact technique or guided swing — rod tip steers fly around obstacles impossible to reach by casting
Boulder pockets	Wotton upstream + Leisenring Lift OR contact straight-down feed into the slot
Slow flats	Dead drift only — swing accelerates fly unacceptably; intermediate line to keep fly in zone

PATTERNS & CAST OF FLIES LOGIC

CATEGORY	PATTERNS & LOGIC
Winged wets (point fly)	Leadwing Coachman, Hare's Ear wet, March Brown wet, Royal Coachman wet — weight and profile
Soft hackles (dropper)	Partridge & Orange, Starling & Herl, Pheasant Tail soft hackle — pulsing tier, mobile in current
SA originals	Tellico, Yallerhammer, Jim Charley, Thunderhead, Crackleback — attractor logic, regional heritage
Attractor hairwings	Soft Hackle Coachman, Green Weenie wet, Crackleback — general suggestion, no hatch needed
Hatch-shift patterns	Yellow Sally soft hackle, BWO soft hackle, Elk Hair Caddis wet — when prolific hatch changes the game
Cast of flies logic	Point: heaviest/most suggestive · Middle dropper: lighter attractor · Top dropper: smallest/lightest

STRIKE DETECTION BY METHOD

METHOD	DETECTION
Traditional swing	Jolting take on tight line — fish often hook themselves; shock loop absorbs explosive takes
Dead drift wet	Subtle pull or tick — raise rod immediately; no tension in system until you create it
Wotton Leisenring Lift	Confident take as fly rises — fish commits, no refusal behavior; lift firmly, don't strike hard
Contact / straight-down	Line-tip deviation, slight tick, or rod-load sensation — subtle; requires total focus on line angle

ROD & GEAR SELECTION

TOPIC	DETAIL
Rod action	Mid-flex or soft-tip 9.5–11 ft in 3–4 wt. Soft tip cushions takes, loads roll cast, works the flies without drying them.
Why not fast action	Fast-action rods dry flies on false casts, create shock on tight-line takes that break tippet, and fight the soft presentation.
Floating line	Ideal for classic swing in 1–3 ft water. Best control, easiest mending, most visibility.
Intermediate line	For water 3–5 ft or slow pools. Gets flies down without the hinge of a sink tip. Slime line or clear camo.
Leader length	12–16 ft total on a 5X base. Longer leaders keep fly line off the water in the Wotton method.
Dropper spacing	20–30" between droppers, open-loop uni-knot on each fly for maximum pulsing movement.

1-Day Intensive — Art of the Wet Fly

7:30 – 8:00 am

Philosophy, the big advantage & gear orientation

PHILOSOPHY + GEAR

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand the four-method framework and why water coverage is the wet fly's primary advantage
- Select a rod action, line type, and assemble a two-fly leader before going to the water
- Establish the step-and-swing discipline as the default approach

KEY CONCEPTS

Mid-flex soft-tip 10 ft 3–4 wt: cushions takes, loads roll cast, works the flies · Floating line for classic swing; intermediate for depth in slow water · Leader: 12–14 ft, 5X, two-fly rig with surgeon's loop dropper 24" up from point · Point fly: winged wet or Tellico; dropper: soft hackle attractor · Grid advantage: systematic coverage beats random casting every time

ACTIVITIES

- Abbreviated leader build: instructor demonstrates, students assemble two-fly rig
- Roll cast turnover test on flat water before going to river

MB *The big advantage with wet fly techniques is they empower the angler to grid off massive amounts of water much quicker than any other method.*

Checkpoint: Each student's two-fly leader turns over cleanly on a roll cast before advancing to the river.

8:00 – 8:15 am

Walk to water

8:15 – 9:45 am

Traditional swing — down-and-across on the step grid

TRADITIONAL

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute the quarter-downstream cast and control swing speed with mending
- Step-and-swing grid from top to bottom of a run without missing lanes
- Develop hang patience — 5-count before recasting
- Read swing lies: riffles, tailouts, seams

KEY CONCEPTS

Quarter-downstream cast: 45° to current · Upstream mend immediately: lets fly sink before tensioning · Belly management: mend to slow, lead rod to speed · Rod tip low, tracking the arc · The hang: fly rises at end of swing — most strikes happen here · Step-and-swing grid: two steps downstream per cast · Shock loop: 8–12" of line between fingers absorbs hard takes

ACTIVITIES

- Swing drill: quarter cast, upstream mend, low rod track, 5-count hang
- Step-and-swing grid: cover a full riffle run top to bottom — instructor confirms coverage
- Speed control: mend to slow vs. lead to speed — partner calls which looks right

Checkpoint: Each student grids a full riffle run systematically. Instructor checks swing speed and hang patience.

9:45 – 10:30 am

Patterns & cast of flies logic for today's water

PATTERNS

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Apply attractor-first logic for Southern Appalachian water
- Assemble or adjust cast of flies with correct point/dropper reasoning
- Identify when a prolific hatch calls for an imitative soft hackle shift

KEY CONCEPTS

Attractors first: Tellico, Yallerhammer, soft hackle Coachman · Soft hackle pulsing tier as upper dropper · Hatch-shift: Yellow Sally, BWO, or Elk Hair Caddis wet when hatch is prolific · Point: heaviest and most suggestive; dropper: lighter, more mobile

ACTIVITIES

- Fly board sort: 5 minutes — attractor vs. imitative split, justify the placement
- Current conditions check: any hatch evidence? Adjust dropper if warranted

MB *Patterns of wets tend to usually be attractors in my part of the country unless there is a prolific hatch. The Tellico and the Yallerhammer have worked here for generations.*

10:30 – 11:15 am

Lunch at water — observe a section before eating, note lie types for afternoon

11:15 am – 12:15 pm

Dead drift wet fly & Leisenring Lift introduction

DEAD DRIFT + LIFT

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand why dead drift demands total line control discipline
- Execute an upstream cast and achieve a tension-free drift on moderate current
- Apply the Leisenring Lift concept at one identified holding lie

KEY CONCEPTS

Dead drift: upstream 45° cast, high rod tracks fly at current speed, zero tension · High rod leads the drift — no slack, no drag — the balance point between both · Strike detection: subtle feel or leader twitch — raise rod immediately · Leisenring Lift: check rod movement 4 ft upstream of target — fly rises on current pressure · Transition: when line tightens, dead drift becomes the swing — use it, don't fight it

ACTIVITIES

- Upstream dead drift drill: flat to moderate water, partner watches leader for drag
- Transition drill: let dead drift become swing — call the tension onset moment
- Leisenring Lift attempt: target one identifiable holding lie, execute the drift-and-lift sequence

MB *The dead drift wet fly technique is among the most difficult — dependent entirely on line control. Even a brief introduction will change how you fish every wet fly for the rest of your life.*

Checkpoint: Each student achieves a 6-second tension-free drift and executes one Leisenring Lift attempt at a holding lie.

12:15 – 1:30 pm

Contact wet fly & complex water coverage

CONTACT

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Execute the straight-down feed technique to reach lies unreachable by casting
- Detect takes through line-tip behavior rather than feel or sight
- Apply rod-tip animation during the swing

KEY CONCEPTS

Straight-down feed: 4-inch line strips, fly dances into complex lies · Rod-tip animation: tap rod blank — vibration pulses into soft hackle fibers · Line-tip indicator: watch the angle, not the fly · Contact grid: half-step coverage, rod sweeps through every slot

ACTIVITIES

- Straight-down feed drill: guide fly around a bend or behind a boulder into the slot
- Rod-tap drill: feel whether the vibration reaches the fly or dies in the rod
- Partner line-tip watch: call takes from line behavior alone

Checkpoint: Each student successfully guides a fly into one complex lie and detects one take through line angle behavior.

1:30 – 2:30 pm

Independent water — method selection & grid discipline

APPLIED

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Self-select the correct method for each section of assigned water
- Grid the run systematically without instructor prompting
- Self-report take detection and method choices at debrief

ACTIVITIES

- Independent 45-minute run: student covers assigned water using all methods learned today
- Instructor observes from distance only — no real-time coaching
- Student self-reports: sections fished, methods used, takes detected, questions arising

MB *The big advantage is real. But only if you fish it with discipline. Systematic coverage is the art.*

Checkpoint: Student completes the run and can describe: which method per section, why, and what took or what was missed.

2:30 – 3:15 pm

Final debrief, written feedback & 30-day plan

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Receive individual written feedback
- Identify one technical and one water-reading priority
- Build a personal 30-day wet fly practice plan

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment: roll cast, leader logic, swing control, dead drift attempt, Leisenring Lift, contact technique

- Individual feedback: one strength, one priority, one thing to do on every future outing
- 30-day plan: assign one method per water-type outing, journal take detection

Checkpoint: Completed assessment returned to each student.